there is no debris of collapsed or demolished structures of earlier strata underneath, of the kind usually encountered under blocks of houses that line roads. Instead, there is ‘only a deep accumulation of small boulders and river pebbles that had been used to pave the street or had been dumped there from time to time when it became necessary to raise the level.’[21]

How visitors and city residents experienced the main street would have depended upon the season. This is because Taxila lacked a drainage system. While there may have been surface drains—such surviving remains have been found in the Fourth Street and in Lane 1—they do not connect with a main drain of the type which would have carried rain water out of the city.[22] So, for all practical purposes, the impressive main street functioned both as a communication axis and wet-weather watercourse. Ashoka would not have enjoyed parading his troops through slushy water flowing down First Street had his arrival been during the monsoon, especially as the flow during downpours was more in the nature of an inundation on account of water from the higher lanes augmenting its own.